26-27 Second Down Report

Farmersville, HSAA, Mt Vernon, Commerce, Valley View, Bells
Generated October 6, 2026. Real games only. Scrimmages are out.

The short version

Second down is more successful because the sticks are shorter, and because we run the ball into that window. The call sheet itself barely changes.

On 1st down you need half the yards to go to count as a success. On 3rd down you need all of them. Second down uses the same half-the-distance rule as 1st down, but the distance is usually less than 10. **96% of 1st downs are 10 or more yards.** On 2nd down, **36% of snaps are 6 yards or fewer**, and the median distance is **8 instead of 10**.

How a snap is scored

- **1st and 2nd down:** a success is at least half the yards to go. A touchdown counts. Penalties are left out of the success rate.
- **3rd and 4th down:** a success is the full distance, or a touchdown.
- **EPA** is expected points added. A short gain on 2nd-and-short can be a success and still be negative EPA, because the model expected the first down.

Down comparison

Every offensive snap this season, the same set as the situation report.

Down	Snaps	Success	EPA / play
1st	174	46%	–0.123
2nd	130	51%	–0.053
3rd	89	33%	–0.267

Where the gap actually is

Penalty snaps are left out below so a flag is not counted as a gain. When 2nd down is still 10 or more, we are worse than 1st-and-10.

Situation	Snaps	Success	Yards	EPA
2nd and 4–6	27	70%	8.7	+0.074
2nd and 7–9	27	59%	9.3	+0.453
2nd and 10+	50	36%	7.0	–0.055
1st and 10+	149	46%	5.9	–0.034

77 of 120 second downs follow a failed 1st down. The median distance on those is still 10. That is the part of 2nd down that looks like 1st down, and it is not a strength.

What we call differently

- We throw more as the down gets later: **34% on 1st, 47% on 2nd, 54% on 3rd.**
- We cut **Horns** from **22% of 1st downs to 8% of 2nd downs.** Horns on 1st is ordinary, not the reason 2nd down grades out.
- In the **4-to-9-yard** window on 2nd down we still run a little over half the time. Those runs are the efficient snaps: **29 carries, 76% success, 8.8 yards, 10% stuffed.**
- The throws in that same window are the explosive ones (**23 attempts, +0.521 EPA, 10.0 yards**) and more boom-or-bust (**35% gain nothing**).

On **2nd-and-10 or more** we throw **56%** of the time. Those passes succeed **32%** of the time. Throwing more on a long 2nd down is not what makes the down look good.

Why 3rd down looks worse

Two separate things are stacked on top of each other.

- The success rule is stricter. A 4-yard gain on 2nd-and-8 is a success. The same gain on 3rd-and-8 is a failure.
- **3rd-and-10 or more** is a pass-heavy down that does not convert: **30 snaps, 73% pass, 7% success, –0.391 EPA.**

At the same **4-to-6 yards**, 2nd down averages **8.7 yards** and 3rd down averages **3.9 yards**. On those 3rd downs we throw **60%** of the time.

What to take from this

- Treat the 2nd-down success rate as the **4-to-9-yard** downs after a partial gain on 1st. That is the down we are good on.
- Do not read **2nd-and-10** as a strength. Success there is **36%**, below 1st-and-10 at **46%**.
- The leak on 3rd down is **3rd-and-long**, where we throw and do not move the chains. On 3rd and 4–6 we also throw more than we do at the same distance on 2nd, and the average gain drops from 8.7 to 3.9.